

Some “Welcome to 431” Survey results for Fall 2026 (n = 45)

Prepared by Thomas E. Love, Ph.D. (and *not* with the use of generative AI) for Class 2: 2026-08-27

Have you reviewed the 431 Course Main Page yet?		
Yes	Sort of, but I need to look at it some more.	Not yet, but I'll be sure to do that soon.
22 (49%)	19	4

Indicate your current feelings about taking this course in statistics and data science						
1 = Deeply Anxious			6 = Enthusiastic			
1	2	3	4	5	6	Mean (SD)
0	3	6	11	16	10	4.6 (1.1)

How comfortable are you with R?						
1 = R? What is that?			6 = I love R and use it all the time.			
1	2	3	4	5	6	Mean (SD)
8	7	11	11	7	2	3.1 (1.4)

How are you feeling? (One or two words from each response, in a word cloud¹)



¹ Visualized with the help of <https://www.freewordcloudgenerator.com/>

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Will Attend 22+ classes in person: 45 Yes (100%)

Will have strong internet where you’re staying this Fall: 45 Yes (100%)

Will have access to a reliable laptop or computer for course work: 44 Yes (98%) ¹ has some concerns

Personal Pronouns: 27 she/her (60%), 17 he/him, 1 she/they

Health care provider or providing medical care for others: 7 Yes (16%), 38 No

If you needed to analyze a small data set right away, which of the following software would you be comfortable using to accomplish that task?	
Excel, Google Sheets, Numbers or some other spreadsheet package	35 (76%)
R	28 (61%)
Python	18 (39%)
MATLAB, SQL, SPSS	6 (13%)
GraphPad	5 (11%)
SAS, Tableau	3 (6.5%)
JMP	2 (4%)
Power BI	1 (2%)

What, if anything, concerns you about this class? (Edited heavily by Dr. Love)

- The most common response was some form of “nothing in particular, at least not yet”.
- A large number of people mentioned issues with managing their time, particularly among those who are starting a new program, and those who are not studying full-time.
- Many seem worried about balancing other commitments (academic and other) with this course.
- Several people have limited (or no) prior experience with either statistics, coding or both.
- Some mentioned previous bad experiences with statistics or coding.
- For some, it’s their first course at the graduate level.
- For some, it’s been quite a while since they took a course like this.
- Some are worried about the pace of the course, or that it will be especially difficult.

We really do want to help you², and we fully believe that all of you can do this.

² Please ask for our help in whichever of the ways described on [our Contact Us page](#) suit you best.

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Why are you taking this course? Responses edited and aggregated by Dr. Love

31/45 (76%) mentioned that the course is **required** by their program, or a program they may enter.

The most common other response was, essentially: **I want to learn more about statistics.**

Here are a few of the other responses I enjoyed, some of which came from multiple people.

- I like statistics!
- I’ve heard great things about the course from someone.
- I’ve met people who’ve taken this course before and liked it.
- I want to **ask better questions.**
- I have previously used SPSS, but I decided to take this course because I wanted to learn R as well.
- While I know some base R, I am looking forward to learning the **tidyverse.**
- I hope to conduct clinical research, and this provides an **important foundation.**
- To build a solid foundation in my understanding of statistics.
- I’m eager to do **more in-depth data analysis** and statistical modeling.
- I want to improve my understanding of how to **better analyze healthcare data.**
- I work with **messy data** and so feel like statistics is especially important.
- I want to **visualize, analyze, and make better sense of my field data.**
- I do the bulk of our lab’s data analysis, and I want to improve my skills and understanding.
- I took one statistics course in college and **I think I should take more!**
- I’m taking this course to **learn something new** and hopefully apply what I learn to my work.
- I want to **present my results in a non-deceptive way** so that they are more widely accessible.

What about the other questions?

Some students mentioned very specific questions or concerns, and in some cases, I’ve emailed them personally to try to help resolve those. I may wind up sharing some general thoughts about those issues in future classes. In addition, I hope to make good use of your responses to:

1. Tell us something interesting or fun (or both) about you.
2. What has made your favorite university classes your favorite?

in the classes to come.

Thanks for reading...